Superstore Sales: Growing, but Discounts Are Eating Profit

Visual report | Superstore orders 2014-2017 (9,994 order lines)

$2.30M	$286K	12.5%	+51%
Total Sales	Total Profit	Profit Margin	Sales Growth 2014-17

The story in five points

1. Business is growing: sales rose 51% and profit nearly doubled between 2014 and 2017.

2. Sales are seasonal: September to December bring the biggest months, led by November.

3. Furniture earns only 2.5% margin, and Tables, Bookcases and Supplies lose money.

4. Discounts above 20% are the main leak: those orders lost $135K in total.

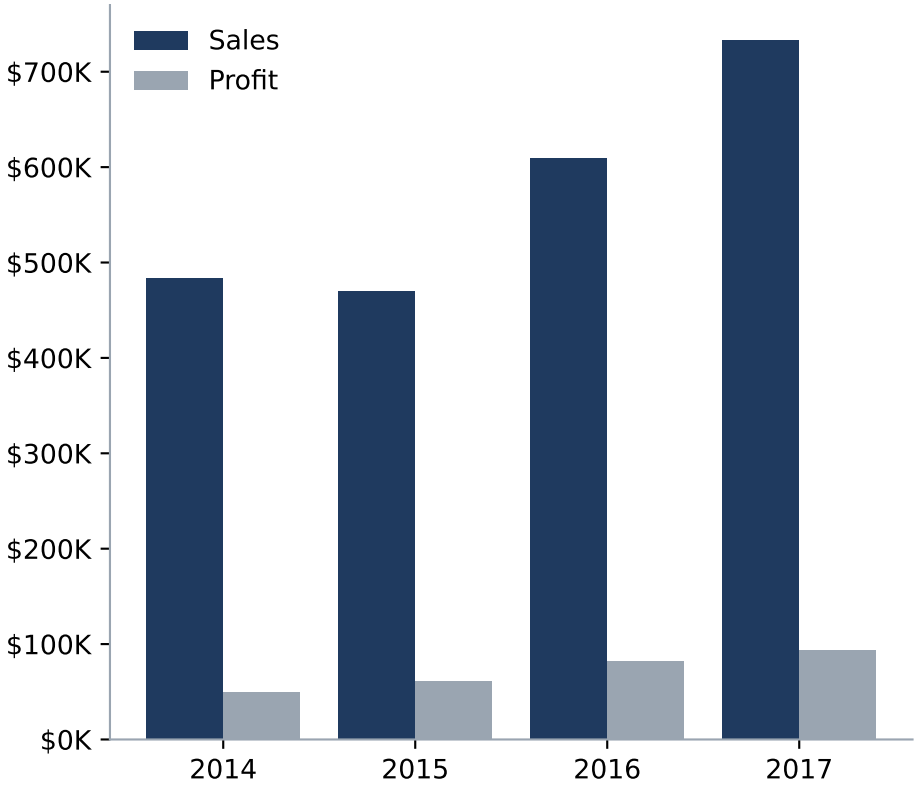
5. The Central region has the lowest margin (7.9%) while the West is the strongest (14.9%).

Recommendation: cap discounts at 20%, review pricing on Tables and Bookcases, and stock up ahead of Q4.

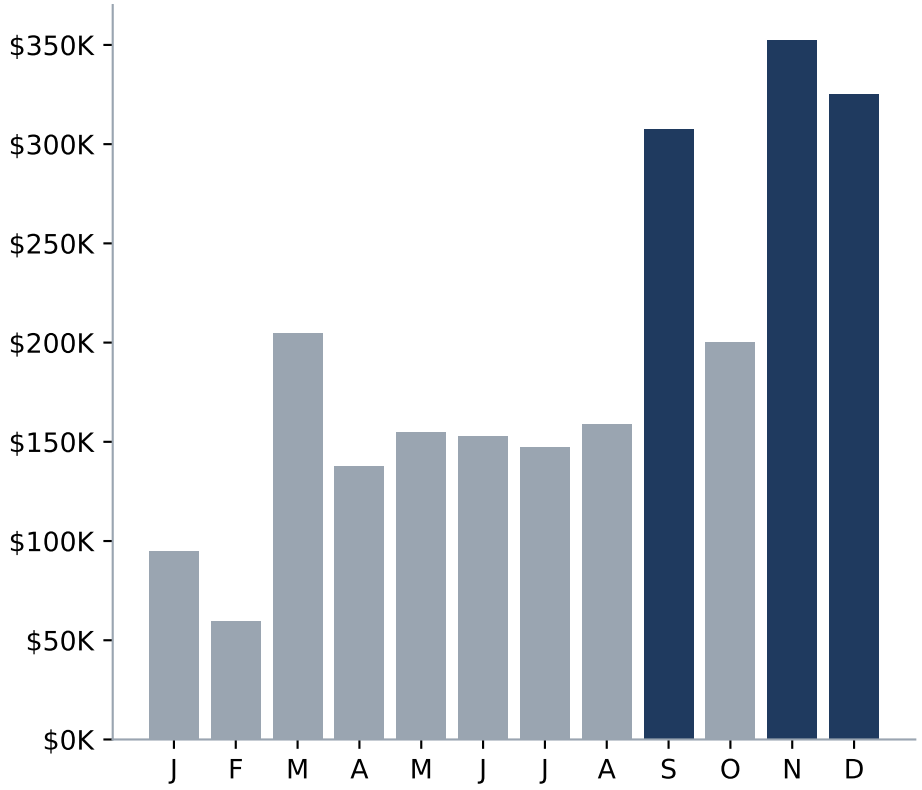
Sales and profit are rising, with a strong year-end peak

Yearly totals and average monthly sales pattern

Sales and profit by year



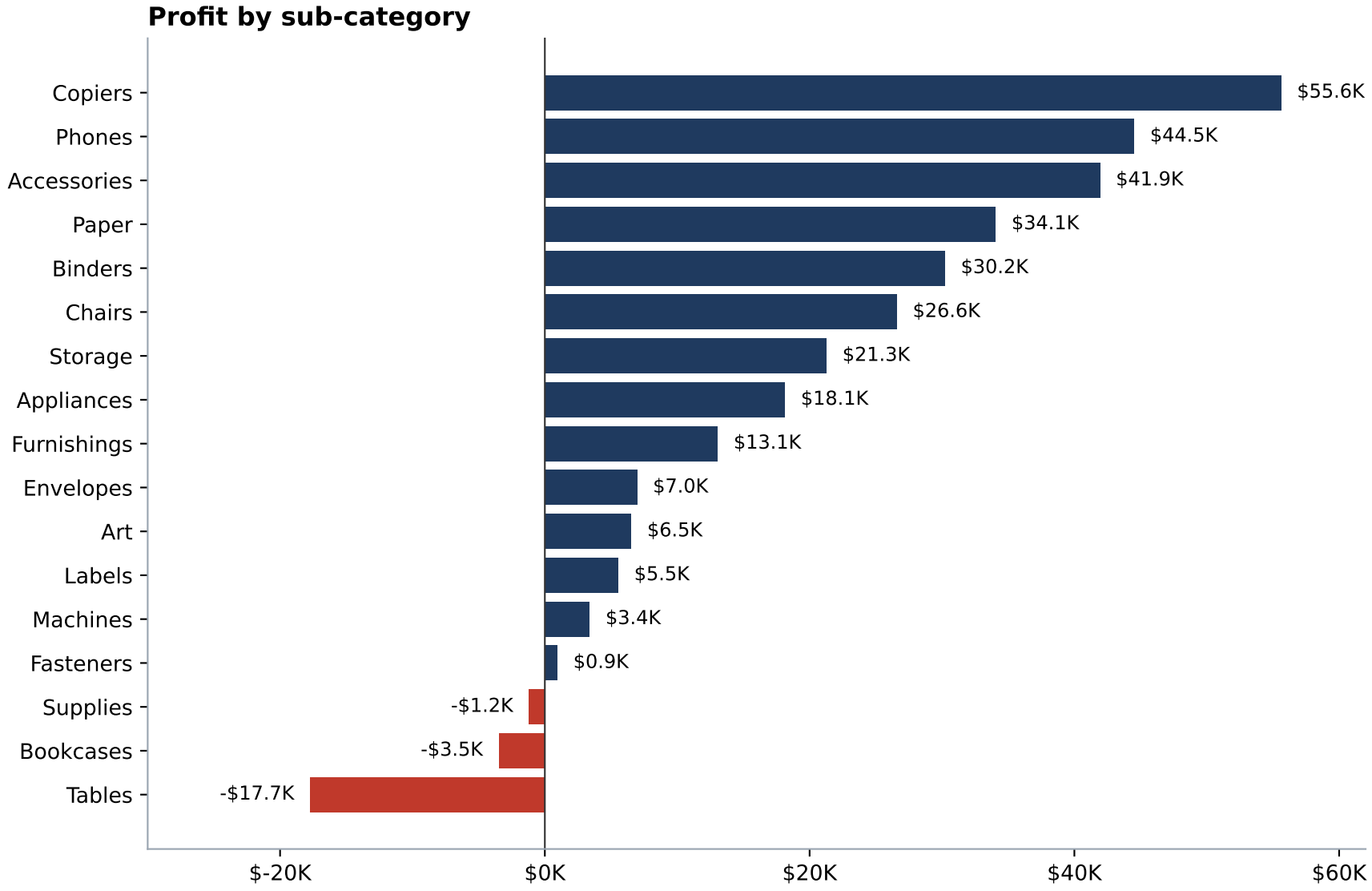
Sales by month (all years combined)



Takeaway: sales grew from $484K (2014) to $733K (2017). November alone brings $352K, about 15% of all sales. Plan inventory and staffing for September to December.

Three sub-categories lose money

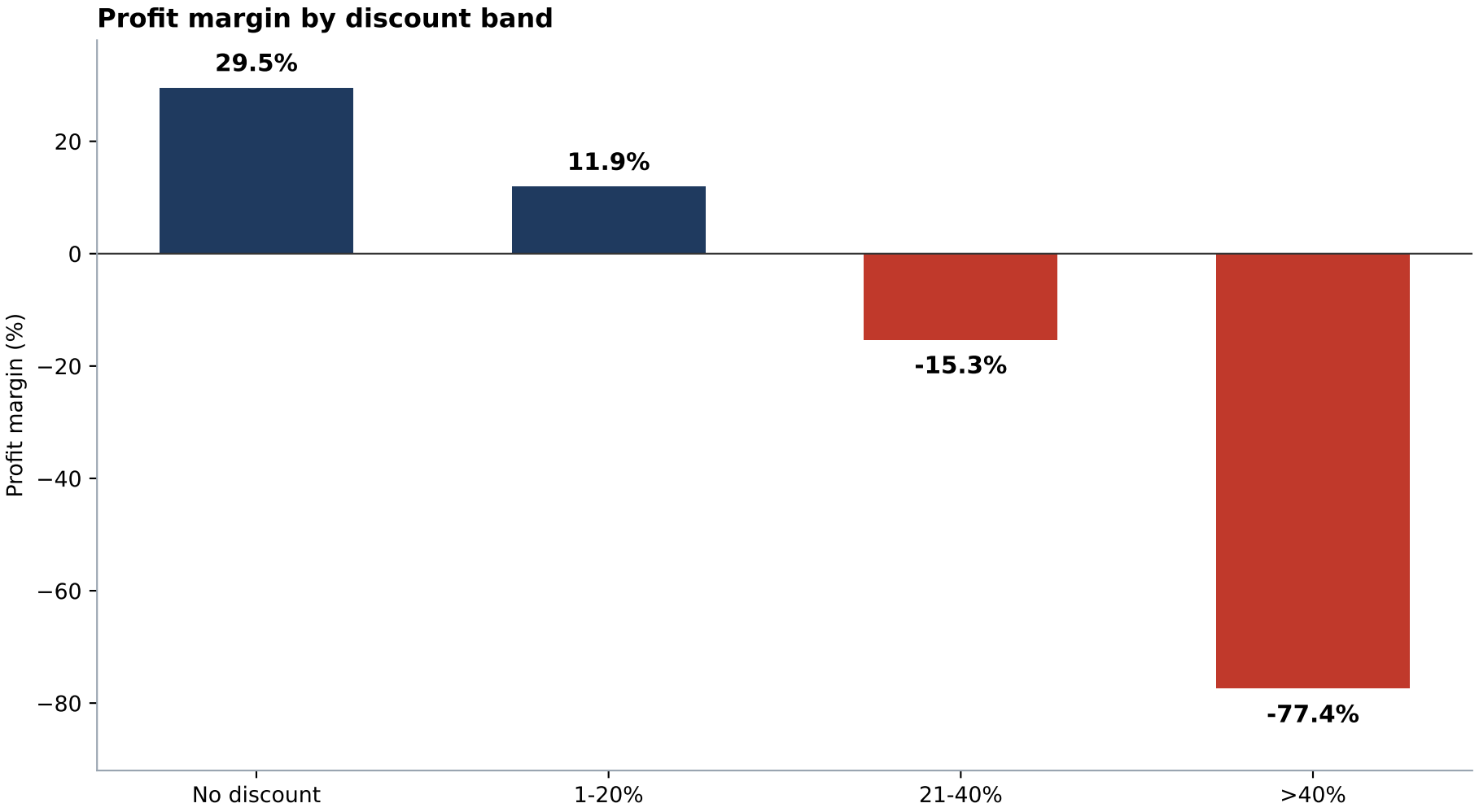
Total profit by sub-category, all years (red = loss)



Takeaway: Tables lose $17.7K despite $207K in sales. Copiers, Phones and Accessories are the profit engines. Furniture overall earns only 2.5% margin versus 17.4% for Technology.

Discounts above 20% turn sales into losses

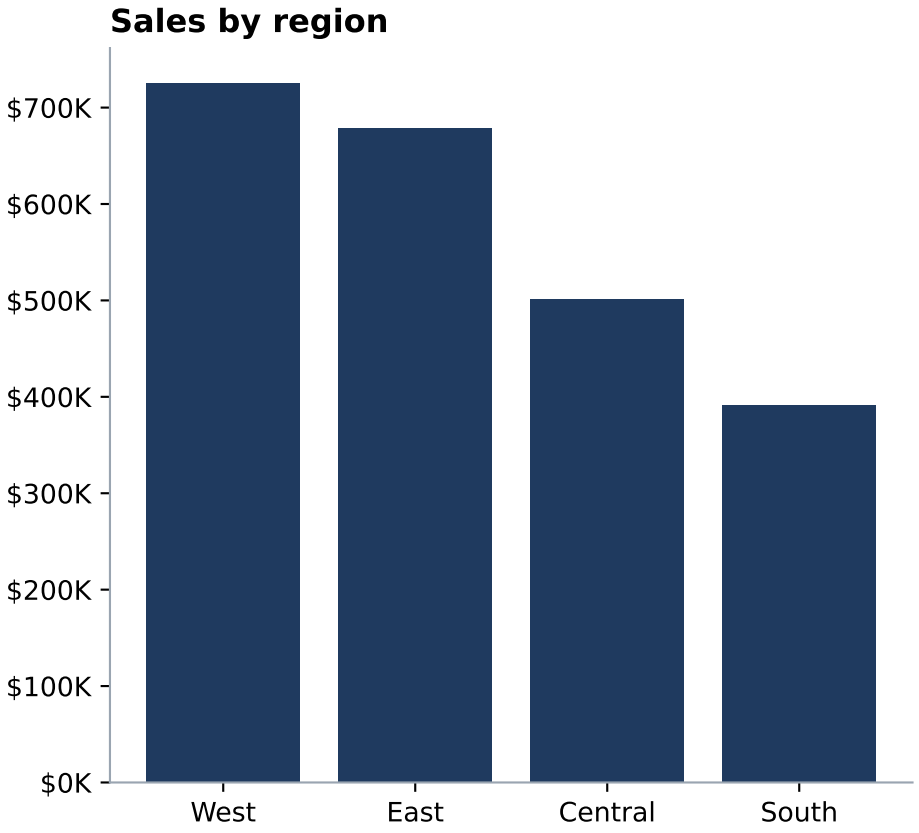
Profit margin by discount level

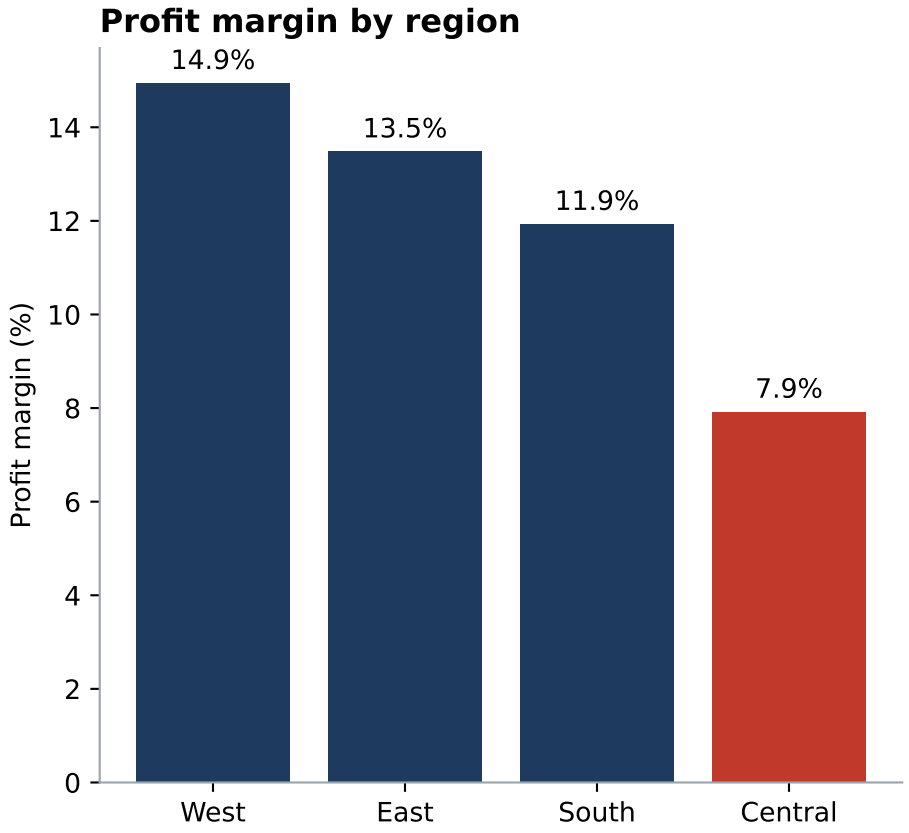


Takeaway: orders with no discount earn 30% margin; orders discounted over 40% lose 77% of their sales value. Together the 21-40% and >40% bands lost $135K. A 20% discount cap is the single biggest profit lever.

The Central region is the weak spot

Sales and profit margin by region





Takeaway: Central sells $501K but keeps only 7.9% as profit, about half the West's 14.9%. Reviewing Central's discounting and product mix is the quickest regional win.

Recommendations

What the business should do next

1 Cap discounts at 20%

Orders above that level lost $135K. Approval needed beyond 20%.

2 Fix Tables and Bookcases

Raise prices or cut discounts; both lose money despite high sales.

3 Grow Technology and Office Supplies

Highest margins (about 17%); focus marketing here.

4 Prepare for Q4

September to December drive the most sales; plan stock and staffing early.

5 Review the Central region

Lowest margin of all regions; check local discounts and product mix.

Tools: Python (pandas, matplotlib). Data: Superstore.csv